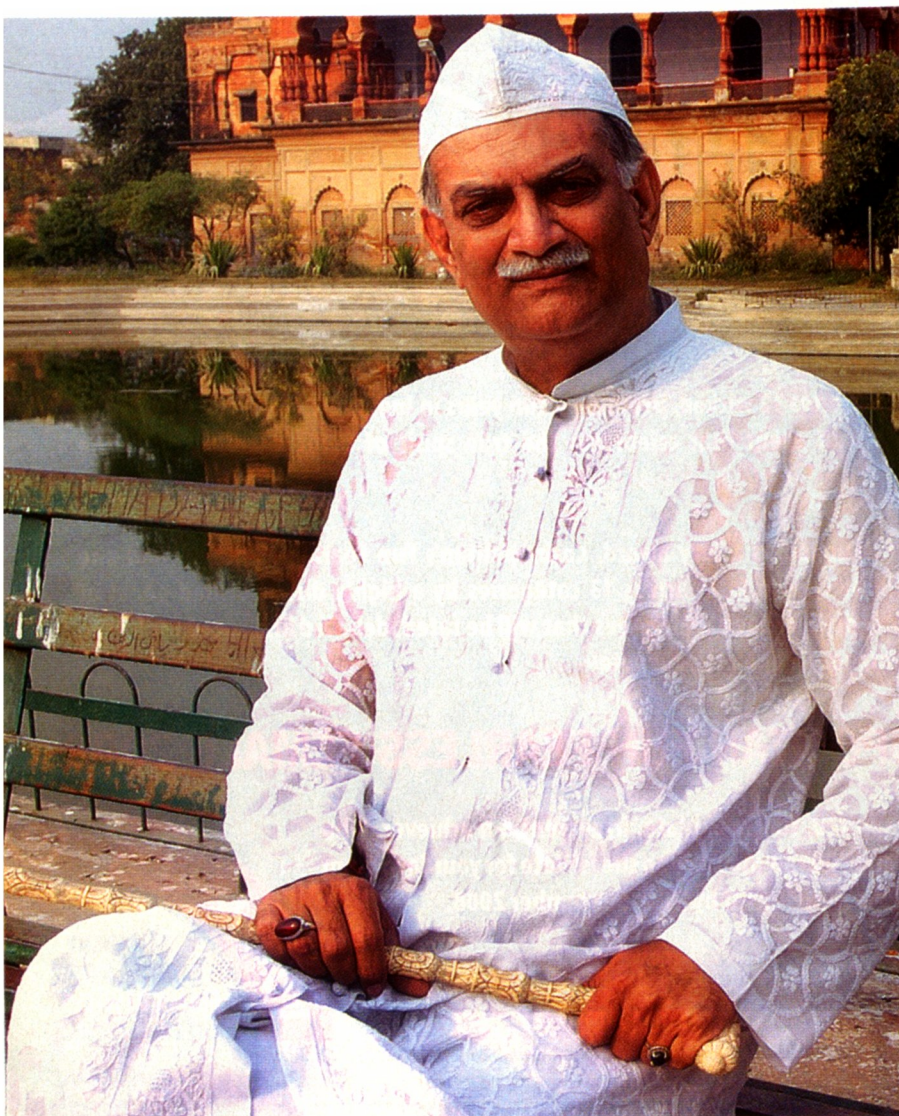




FAKE NAWAB

"Some members of the foundation are not genuine descendants of Awadh rulers. It's time to expose the impostors."

IBRAHIM ALI KHAN, PRESIDENT, RFA



"First the East India Company, now my own relatives have conspired to fudge facts to defame me."

JAFAR MIR ABDULLAH OF SHEESH MAHAL

Descendants of Lucknow's royal Awadh family battle it out over titles, while its history goes for a toss

■ By Farzand Ahmed

In his famous *Shatranj ke Khiladi*, Munshi Premchand highlights the lifestyle of Lucknow's erstwhile nawabs. The twist in the tale includes the palace intrigues which helped the East India Company capture Wajid Ali Shah, the 10th and the last nawab of Awadh (now Lucknow).

The nawabi era may have ended but the palace intrigue lives on, thanks to their descendants trying to rubbish each other's claim to the lineage. The modern-day battle revolves around the Royal Family of Awadh (RFA), a foundation comprising descendants of nawabs and kings. They have launched a campaign to prove that Jafar Mir

Abdullah, who lives in Sheesh Mahal, the traditional residence of the rulers of Awadh, is a 'fake' nawab. The fact that they are all relatives only adds spice to the controversy. "The time has come to expose the impostor who has been indulging in cultural fraud and fleecing foreign tourists openly," says RFA President Nawab Ibrahim Ali Khan Shishmahal. Jafar Mir dismisses the allegations by saying, "My own relatives have conspired to fudge facts to defame me. I pity them."

The current controversy began after Ibrahim Ali became president of the RFA last year and launched a campaign to identify what he termed as "the real nawabs". He discovered that "certain members of the foundation

were not genuine descendants of Awadh rulers".

Sitting in Sheesh Mahal Kothi with showcases stuffed with genealogical charts in Persian and Urdu, Jafar Mir asserts that Ibrahim Ali hails from the Vaziers' family. The rulers of Awadh were from two categories—Mughal subedars or nawab vaziers and, under Nawab Ghaziuddin Haider when they were officially addressed as nawabs. Jafar Mir says he is a direct descendant of Imam Ali Raza, the eighth imam of the Shia sect. He also claims to have "direct links" with Muhammad Ali Shah, the third king of Awadh from his maternal side.

The royal battle has taken a bizarre turn with Shahanshah Mirza of the RFA